

Content Analysis

- A Research Method for Social Science



Online Emotional Communities · OwlKitty Case Study

Example Research Question:

"How do YouTube commenters construct emotional communities around cat-centered parody content?"





By the end of this presentation, you will be able to:



01

EXPLAIN

Explain how content analysis can examine online community-building.



02

APPLY

Apply a two-dimensional codebook to comments and justify your coding decisions.

WHAT IS CONTENT ANALYSIS?



Content Analysis = a systematic, replicable method for identifying and interpreting patterns in text, images, or media — used to answer social science research questions.

The Most Important Distinction:

MANIFEST CONTENT

Surface level — what is literally said or shown

"This cat is so cute!!"

→ Simple: positive sentiment, uses 'cute'

Basic — what words are used

LATENT CONTENT

Deeper meaning — what is implied or constructed

"This cat is so cute!!"

→ Possible shared affection; context matters

Interpreting meaning in context

Content analysis can examine both manifest content and latent content.



*"You are a Barbie fan. I am a Barbie fan.
We both just watched a cat replace Margot Robbie.
Now we feel like we know each other. Why?"*

AFFECTIVE PUBLICS

Zizi Papacharissi (2015)

Affective publics offers a lens for examining how shared feelings and networked expression connect people online. Shared emotion may support affiliation; it does not by itself prove a lasting community.

FOR OWLKITTY BARBIE

Viewers may share affection for Lizzy and familiarity with Barbie. We can look for language that invites other viewers to connect around these references.

Question to explore: When do shared cultural references become signals of belonging?



MEET OWLKITTY.

Your favorite Movie Kitty.



OwlKitty

@OwlKitty · 2.5M subscribers · 101 videos

Lizzy (stage name: OwlKitty) is a two-year-old cat living in Portland, Oregon. She stars in ...more

[owl-kitty.com](#) and 2 more links

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Titanic with a Cat (Behind the Scenes)

OwlKitty · 2.5M views · 4 years ago

So you wanna go to a real party? Here's a behind the scenes look at the making of OwlKitty's Titanic! #OwlKitty #Titanic #BehindtheScenes



Barbie with a Cat



OwlKitty

2.5M subscribers



3.8M views · 2 years ago · #OwlKitty #Ken #Barbie

A Parody of the Barbie movie, starring OwlKitty

#Barbie #OwlKitty #Ken #funny ...more

3,670 Comments

Sort by



Add a comment...

@EclecticBear · 2 years ago

Why do I feel like Ryan Gosling would agree to do a whole movie of this.

Translate to Chinese (China)

9.2K



Reply

25 replies

STEP 1: SAMPLING — WHICH COMMENTS DO WE STUDY?

Before coding, define the population and decide whether to study all eligible comments or a sample. Document your selection rules, collection date, and treatment of replies.

WHICH VIDEO(S)?

**One viral video? Multiple videos?
Specific channel?**

Scope shapes interpretation. More videos do not automatically make a sample representative.

Illustrative case: OwlKitty Barbie, selected for its cat-centered film parody.

WHICH COMMENTS?

**Top comments? Random sample?
First 100?**

Affects representativeness — top comments $\neq$ typical commenter

e.g. Random sample of 50 comments per video

WHAT TIME FRAME?

**All-time? Last month? First week
of posting?**

Affects temporal validity — early comments $\neq$ current community norms

e.g. Comments posted within first 30 days

STEP 2: CODING — SETTING A CODING SCHEME



Practice codebook: assign one code per dimension to each comment. Explain your evidence.

DIMENSION 1 Community-Building Language

Does the comment signal shared identity, cultural references, or an invitation to other viewers?

YES

Explicit address to other viewers, shared identity ("we/us"), or invitation to connect

PARTIAL

Implicit shared cultural reference or in-joke, without explicit address or shared identity

NO

Purely individual expression — no reference to shared experience or community

DIMENSION 2 Anthropomorphization

Does this comment project human thoughts, feelings, personality, or inner life onto the cat?

YES

Clearly gives the cat human thoughts, intentions, personality, or a human performance role

PARTIAL

Tentative human comparison; a human trait is suggested but remains ambiguous

NO

Treats cat as animal — describes behaviors without projecting human inner life



projected)

"Model 1: Was (shared lookalike identity) and 2: Was (human inner life)

⚡ YOUR TURN! 🐱 60 SECONDS — WORK IN PAIRS!

	Comment	D1: Community	D2: Anthro
 1	"Lizzy understood the assignment better than most of the actual cast 🐱"	Y / P / N	Y / P / N
 2	"I came here after watching the real movie and honestly this is more satisfying"	Y / P / N	Y / P / N
 3	"Anyone else think Lizzy has more screen presence than Margot Robbie?? asking for a friend "	Y / P / N	Y / P / N
 4	"The editing on this is incredible, I have watched it 4 times already"	Y / P / N	Y / P / N

Practice comments are illustrative examples, not a verified research sample. Explain your evidence.



DEBRIEF — SUGGESTED CODES



1

"Lizzy understood the assignment..."

D1: PARTIAL

D2: YES

D1: implicit meme reference. D2: human competence attributed to the cat.

2

"...more satisfying than real movie"

D1: PARTIAL

D2: NO

D1: shared film reference, no direct address. D2: no human trait assigned to the cat.

3

"Anyone else think Lizzy has more screen presence..."

D1: YES

D2: YES

D1: "Anyone else" addresses viewers. D2: human performance quality assigned to the cat.

4

"The editing is incredible..."

D1: NO

D2: NO

D1: purely individual reaction to craft — no address to others. D2: cat not present as character here

Compare independent codes, discuss disagreements, and refine definitions. Formal research needs an appropriate reliability measure.

STEP 3: INTERPRETING THE PRACTICE

What can these examples suggest, and what would require further evidence?

1

Illustrative Patterns

Our suggested codes identify one explicit community cue, two implicit cues, and one comment without such cues. These four practice examples cannot estimate how common the patterns are.

2

A Hypothesis to Explore

Shared references and humanized portrayals of a cat may support affiliation. These examples do not establish that parody causes community formation.

3

What We Need Next

Use a defined sample, contextual reading, and independent coding. Testing a parody effect would also require a suitable comparison and research design.

WHAT YOU NOW KNOW

Content Analysis: A Method With Real Depth

-  Content analysis can examine manifest content and latent meaning using explicit, documented coding rules.
-  Sampling decisions come before coding — which comments, which videos, which time frame?
-  Two coding dimensions let us compare community cues with anthropomorphization in the same comments.
-  Affective publics provides a theoretical lens. Claims about community formation need evidence beyond this exercise.

How would you adapt this codebook for another online community?





Gagné's Nine Events of Instruction



Stimulus-Based Interpretive Exercise

Constructivism

Built on students' existing social media literacy, then scaffolded upward through manifest to latent distinction, sampling decisions, and theory connection — each step adding analytical complexity

Sources: Zakrajsek & Nilson (2023), Teaching at Its Best (5th ed.); Papacharissi (2015), Affective Publics.

Reliability: Krippendorff (2004), doi:10.1111/j.1468-2958.2004.tb00738.x. Media: OwlKitty, YouTube.

AI assistance: Claude (Anthropic), acknowledged in the original deck. Full references in speaker notes.

